

Memories in the cloud

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Synopsis: technopoetic work of autofictional bent that examines the configurations of memory and subjectivity in a landscape of digital hyperconnectivity, mediated by cloud storage, data analytics, and artificial intelligence.

Current Stage: *Memories in the cloud* Memories in the Cloud is currently in the writing and materials curation phase. It is developing as a modular creative work geared toward expanded exhibition formats, from which a video-essayistic-poetic dimension emerges in dialogue with other artistic disciplines and live performances.

Introduction and Conceptual Framework

When I moved to Argentina in 2015, I began to cultivate with greater emphasis a traveling archive of spontaneous records: recordings made with my mobile phone, webcam, and video calls. Today, many of those records—accessible through hard drives and playback systems, point, most of the time, to moments that my own memory is unable to recall.

“Computers have conflated memory with storage, the ephemeral with the enduring. Rather than storing memories, we now put things “into memory,” both consciously and unconsciously” (Wendy Hui Kyong Chun, p.133). “Memory and storage are different. Memory stems from the same Sanskrit root for *martyr* and is related to the ancient Greek term for baneful, fastidious. Memory contains within it the act of repetition: it is an act of commemoration—a process of recollecting or remembering. In contrast, a store, according to the OED, stems from the Old French term *estorer* meaning “to build, establish, furnish.” A store—like an archive—is both what is stored and its location” (Wendy Hui Kyong Chun, p.133).

The distinction posed by Chun between memory and storage highlights how the digital archive is rigid and unchangeable, housing data that, once saved, remains fixed and immutable in its location and content. Memory, on the other hand, is imprecise and fluctuating; it relates to the act of remembering and recreating, which inevitably implies modifications, reinterpretations, and omissions. These tensions between memory and storage seem today certainly heightened by cloud storage systems, data analytics, and generative models of image and audio, with which we are progressively witnessing the loss of the evidentiary character of the moving image.

The more we entrust machines and cloud servers with the capacity to remember, the further we distance ourselves from the practice of personal memory. This shift not only affects our relationship with memories but also implies a distancing from our own subjectivity and the connections that shape it. The storage of files has evolved toward a model of seriality where data interconnects and constantly updates in the cloud, redefining the function of each device, which now operates as part of an integrated and dynamic system. Jorge Carrión states in *Los campos electromagnéticos* that, “in the face of the dizzying succession of revolutionary innovations that form part of a single great revolution, general reflection becomes imperative at the expense of celebrating the new version of an artificial intelligence tool that – as happens with iPhones– is above all part of a mutant series and an interconnected device environment, not a singular identity. Everything is inscribed in the logic of digitization and seriality that fuels the absurd growth of artificial intelligence (p. 42)”.

In the current context, it is possible that our memories stored in the cloud—and even those that are not—are feeding, without us hardly noticing, the immense training banks of generative models, with which increasingly convincing and indistinguishable synthetic simulations are produced from those images and sounds that we call “real.” Where do the boundaries between the real and the simulated blur? Where do the false and the artificial meet? Does such a thing as an aesthetic of the artificial exist? Will there come a time when we doubt even the veracity of our own digital memories? *Memorias en la nube* wants to play with these questions; to tension them, take them to the limit, and why not, to the absurdity of the auto-fictional narrative. If the archive is rigid and unchangeable, unlike memory, why not impregnate the archive with the same imprecisions that define memory, making it more ductile and malleable?

Aesthetic Treatment

The proposal slips between the real and the imagined, showcasing images that range from spontaneous recordings captured with mobile phones, webcams, and video calls, to others that, despite their artificiality, seem to replicate those qualities, imitating the texture and format of the archive, thereby blurring the boundaries between the recorded and the synthetic. The visual textures, often pixelated and blurred, create an atmosphere of simulated reality. A narrated voice is perceived as strangely synthetic, almost monstrous, yet still feeling human and hypnotic. That voice guides the viewer through personal reflections, philosophical monologues, and intimate memories. The rhythm is characterized by a meditative and fragmented fluidity, reflecting the nature of memory and the flow of thoughts. Human figures in the materials, in polygonal forms, may come to resemble NPCs pulled from a PlayStation 2 video game, as if their lack of definition reflected the vagueness and mutability of memories. Transitions between scenes and themes are smooth yet unpredictable, as if memories and reflections intertwined spontaneously, generating a narrative structure that follows the free course of mental association. Small glitches and distortions evoke the voids and failures of memory. The work advances organically, without a strict linear progression, alternating between intimate and philosophical moments with a cadence that oscillates between the paused and the suddenly dynamic. The sound design amplifies the immersion, fusing ambient sounds with minimalist strings and electronic layers that intensify the emotional state of the narrative. Everything converges in an intriguing atmosphere that unveils scattered fragments of memory and sensations of loss.

Technique

The proposal defines itself as technopoetic, insofar as it uses the technologies themselves as both medium and object of reflection at the same time. The central premise at the formal level is to intervene in the archive—that is, my existing audiovisual materials—so that they resemble artificial synthetic images, and vice versa: to make the synthetically generated images imitate the texture, format, and technical qualities of my archive. While it will work from certain thematic axes, the creation process is understood as iterative and dialogic. Sometimes, sonic experimentation will guide the search for images or texts, and other times it will be the reverse. A written text or idea can inspire the creation or search for specific images, just as the discovery of a particular image can orient the research, motivating the writing of a text or the search for a relevant quote. Through video-essayistic editing, the goal is to integrate these two worlds: the archive and the artificial image, as if both could be exchanged, confused, and mutually feed into each other.



Prueba de intervención en archivo



Prueba de "archivo" generado sintéticamente

Referentes artísticos

Heart of a Dog (2015)

La película de Laurie Anderson es un excelente referente de la persistencia y cadencia de la voz narrada, y de la integración de diversos soportes.

Processes

Archive Curation

Selection of Materials: A review and selection of the audiovisual materials collected during my last nine years in Argentina is carried out. Among possible curatorial axes emerge the video calls with my grandmother, which evidence her memory loss before she passed away; the death of my dog and the resignification of his records; conversations with friends about quantum physics and simulated realities; the purple spots in many of my records, caused by dead pixels in my phone's sensor after recording a laser show during a presentation of expanded music; everyday images, urban landscapes, and travel records.

Displacement of Meaning: Artificial intelligence acts as a filter that allows extracting the files from their original context and reconfiguring them. Some human figures, such as past loves with whom I lost all contact, might appear faceless, while other old friends and acquaintances could be transformed into NPCs, evoking diffuse memories and generic identities. This intervention allows me to avoid the personal implications of including certain people, separating the records from the circumstances in which they were created, transferring them to new narrative and visual spaces, and freeing the narrative from the constraints of the archive.

Narration

The writing process is conceived as a fragmented meditation, intertwining personal memories, philosophical reflections, and quotes from theoretical texts with original poems that emerge as moments of pause and emotional resonance. The structure allows for a free drift, in which memory and imagination constantly intersect, seeking to amplify questions and emotions rather than offer answers.

Generation of Synthetic Images

Imitation: Realistic artificial intelligence synthetic generation models will be used that imitate the texture and format of the files, blurring the boundaries between the documentary and the generated.

Abstraction: In addition to replicating the files, the generated images may also be more abstract, such as visual representations of the subconscious articulated in the narration.

Creation of Sound Atmospheres

The sound atmospheres will be constructed primarily with my synthesizer, generating textures that interact with the images. Sometimes the archive will motivate the sound creation, and other times it will be the sound that guides the search and creation of images.

Intervention and Editing

Narrated Voice: A combination of voice generation techniques will be used, where the human interpretation of the texts is preserved, but the original voice will be replaced through voice-changing techniques with a custom-designed voice that sounds less human, more synthetic and computerized, and—if desired—more monstrous.

Video-Essayistic Editing: The editing is based on a logic of constant intervention and feedback between materials of different natures. Images from the personal archive are alternated with synthetically generated ones. The sound design, both in the narration and in the effects, contributes to creating a cohesive narrative that integrates the diversity of materials.

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Bibliography:

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- Carrión, J (2023). *Los campos electromagnéticos: Teorías y prácticas de la escritura artificial*. Caja Negra